



Würzburg Residence

An extravagant showcase of the exuberant arts and crafts of the Rococo period

Now a city in Bavaria, southern Germany, in the 18th century, Würzburg was a small independent state ruled by prince-bishops. In 1720, Prince-Bishop Johann Philipp Franz von Schönborn ordered his architect Balthasar Neumann to begin construction of a lavish new palace. Aided by other prominent architects from Germany and France, Neumann created a building that was a fusion of European Baroque styles, costing 1.5 million guilders (when a guilder was a worker's weekly wage). The exterior was completed by 1744, but work continued for another quarter century on the interior—a masterpiece of ornamental carving, stucco, glass, and gilt dominated by the vast, colorful ceiling and wall paintings of Venetian Rococo artist Giovanni Battista Tiepolo.

Rebuilding history

In 1945, much of the building was destroyed by Allied bombing. The sections that survived intact fortunately included the Imperial Hall, the main staircase and vestibule with their irreplaceable Tiepolo frescoes, and the White Hall with its prodigious stucco work. Inspired efforts by modern craftsmen have since recreated other parts of the original interior. The residence was declared a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 1981.



◀ FOUNTAIN FIGURE

This statue of Walther von der Vogelweide, a renowned medieval German love poet, forms part of the Frankonia fountain in the residence's forecourt.



THE GARDENS

The gardens of the Würzburg Residence had to be designed to fit within the shape of the town's fortifications, so they follow the outline of angular bastions. The formal Court Garden in Baroque style next to the house extends into meadow and woods in the English style.

